

Brookesia micra

Micro leaf chameleon



Length 1½ in (30 mm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Partly arboreal
Status Near threatened

Location N. Madagascar



Thought to be the smallest reptile in the world, this tiny chameleon was found in 2012 on a small islet off the north coast of Madagascar. It lives on the rainforest floor among leaf litter, and feeds on small invertebrates. Males, which are slightly smaller than females, cling to the female's back and are carried around by her until she is ready to mate. The eggs are about 2.5mm long.

*Furcifer pardalis*

Panther chameleon



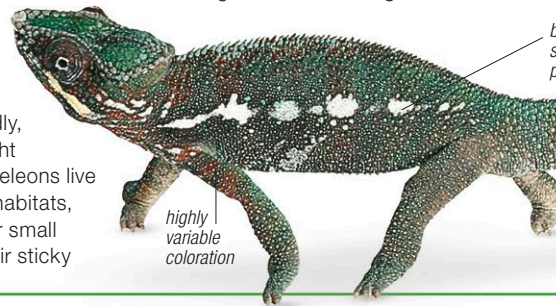
Length 16–20½ in (40–52 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location Reunion Island, E. and N. Madagascar



Madagascar and its neighboring islands have over 70 species of chameleons, which is more than in any similarly sized region of the world. The panther chameleon, particularly the adult male, is one of the most brightly colored, with a bewildering array of color schemes, including green, brick-red, turquoise, or any combination of these hues. It can change its color rapidly, but it usually retains its bright lateral stripe. Panther chameleons live in lightly wooded, scrubby habitats, and catch insects and other small animals by shooting out their sticky

tongues, which can be longer than the rest of their bodies. They are usually slow-moving, but at the onset of the breeding season, males fight for



highly variable coloration

CHANGING COLOR

Chameleons are famous for being able to change color for camouflage, but in most species, color is equally important as a means of communication. Male panther chameleons attract females by producing sudden flushes of color, while females change color when pregnant to signal that they are not receptive to mating.



territories. Each year, females lay several clutches of 12–50 eggs, burying them in moist soil.

FLATTENED SNOOT

One of the larger chameleons, the panther chameleon has a bony, flattened region on top of its snout, fringed with enlarged scales. The male has a small nasal appendage, while the female (shown left) has none.

prehensile tail

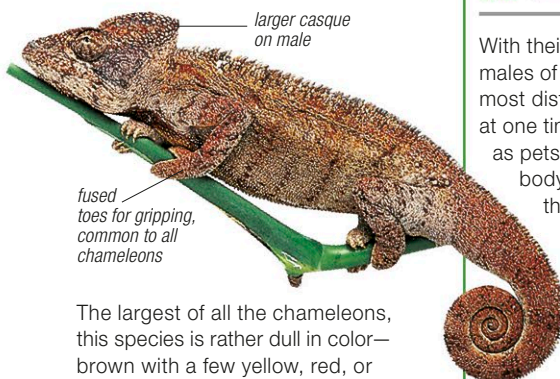
Furcifer oustaleti

Oustalet's chameleon



Length 20–27 in (50–68 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location Madagascar



larger casque on male

fused toes for gripping, common to all chameleons

The largest of all the chameleons, this species is rather dull in color—brown with a few yellow, red, or greenish spots—and has no horns. However, it has a large, flattened casque (protuberance) over its head and neck. Unusually for a chameleon, the male is less colorful than the female, but he becomes more flushed with color during courtship. Females lay approximately 50 eggs, in soil or leaf litter. Slow and deliberate in its movements, Oustalet's chameleon carefully stalks prey such as insects and small vertebrates before capturing them with its extendible, sticky tongue. It defends itself against predatory snakes and birds by inflating its body, presenting its side to the enemy, and opening its mouth wide; it may also hiss and bite.

Trioceros jacksonii

Jackson's chameleon



Length 8–12 in (20–30 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location E. Africa, introduced in Hawaii



With their 3 forward-pointing horns, males of this species are among the most distinctive of all chameleons, and at one time were often caught and sold as pets. Both sexes have a flattened body and serrated crest along the back, with a bony casque

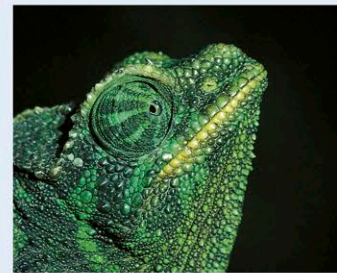


serrated crest along the back

HORNS ON MALE

The male Jackson's chameleon has 3 long, pointed, bony horns on the front of his head, used in fights with other males over territory.

HORNLESS FEMALE



Male and female Jackson's chameleons are easily told apart: the female (shown above) is usually stockier than the male, and the horns are tiny or absent.

over the neck. Their normal color is green, but specimens that live in East Africa's mountain forests are usually brighter and larger than ones that live lower down. Jackson's chameleon relies primarily on its camouflage to avoid being attacked. However, if cornered, it inflates its body and gives a menacing hiss. Females are live-bearing, producing 2 litters of up to 50 young each year. Newborns are light brown, but turn green at about 4 months. In males, horns start to form about 2 months later. In the wild, the lifespan of Jackson's chameleon is probably 2–3 years.

Calumma parsonii

Parson's chameleon

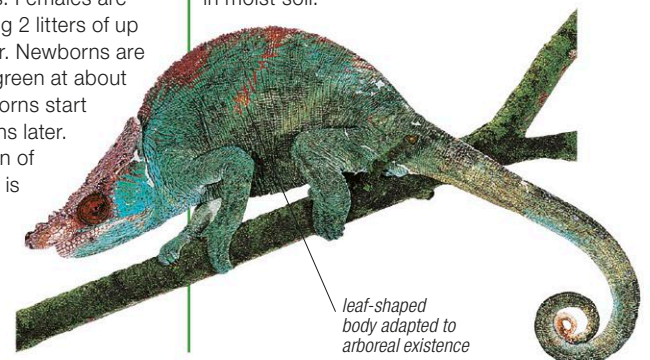


Length 20–23½ in (50–60 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Near threatened

Location N. and E. Madagascar



This very large, deep-bodied chameleon is usually greenish, but may also be blue. The male is larger and more colorful than the female, with a larger casque (protuberance) on the top of the head and a warty, flattened horn—absent in females—on the snout. Parson's chameleon lives mainly in the trees and is slow-moving, relying on camouflage to escape detection. Defensive behavior includes inflating its body, hissing, or biting, and it may become more brightly colored. Males of this species are highly territorial, and mate with receptive females without preliminaries. The female lays 16–38 eggs, burying them in a hole dug in moist soil.



leaf-shaped body adapted to arboreal existence